

Walking under the dim glow of the lined-up streetlights, he was too lost in thought to notice the hands reaching out for him. Two large hands grabbed Adam Herrick by the collar and dragged him into an alleyway. As he was pulled into the dark side street where the streetlights couldn't reach, Adam opened his mouth to scream in terror. But another hand clamped down over his mouth. Though he thrashed and resisted with all his might, Adam Herrick was a skinny man. Average height, black hair, and black eyes. Enveloped by the darkness, he continued to struggle, grasping the thick wrists that held his collar with his own thin arms. He yanked at them, but it was useless. Whatever was dragging him into the alley carried him off as if it were nothing.

Just as the light from the streetlamps began to look like a distant, sparse speck, he suddenly felt himself spun around. His back slammed against the wall, and he groaned in pain.

"Ad, where is Mr. Wood's money?" a voice asked, bringing its face right up to Adam's.

"Mark? You... It's good... to see you," Adam said, feeling Mark's breath on his face.

"I'm asking you again! Where is Mr. Wood's money?" Mark barked, punching Adam furiously in the stomach. It was a blow that knocked out all the breath he needed to scream. Adam wanted to curl up in pain and lie on the ground, but Mark wouldn't let him, holding him upright by his collar with a single hand.

"Your payment date has passed," Mark said through gritted teeth. Then, spinning Adam around with him, he threw him to the ground. Adam wanted to scream, but no sound came out. First, he fell heavily onto his right arm with an immense jolt of pain. He rolled a few times, crashing into another object he guessed was a trash can. As pain engulfed his entire body, he just lay there on the ground. He didn't have the strength to stand up, let alone attack Mark. He knew that even if he managed to strike back, he stood no chance against the gargantuan Mark. His only hope was that Mark would leave him alone as he writhed on the ground. But it didn't go as he hoped.

This time, Mark's boot struck Adam's face with brute force. Adam was thrown backward, certain his nose had been shattered. Feeling the taste of warm metal filling his mouth, he tried to bring his hands to his nose. A small shriek escaped his throat as the boot, covered in sharp spikes, crushed his hand.

Adam could feel his heart slowing down. He tried to spit out the tiny fragments of teeth floating around in his mouth. Instead of moving his lips, he decided to clear the shards with his tongue. A kick to his shoulder sent him rolling onto his back, the broken pieces of teeth rattling in his mouth. As his shoulder burned with pain, Mark spoke: "This is our last warning to you, Ad. This is your last chance to pay your debt. Just a day or two. In two days, Mr. Wood will either have his money back, or he'll enjoy the show while his dogs eat you alive. Make your choice, Ad. This is your last chance." Mark pressed his boot down onto Adam's chest. Adam closed his eyes tightly and clenched his remaining teeth, bracing himself for his ribs to snap one by one.

"Do you understand me?" Mark asked furiously. "Two days left!"

After taking his foot off Adam, Mark spat on him. Then, he began to walk away. Disappearing into the dark night was child's play for him, though Adam couldn't see him leave anyway. Feeling too exhausted to even open his eyes, a tear rolled down his cheek. Then another, and

another... His entire body throbbed with agony. Even breathing hurt. It felt as though his ribs were stabbing into him with every breath he took.

Finally, his eyes fluttered open. Looking up at the dark sky, he saw dark red spots dancing before his eyes. He slowly parted his mouth a few centimeters and, using his tongue, pushed out the shards of teeth he was trying not to swallow. As he rid himself of the teeth, more blood flooded his mouth—more of that metallic taste. He lacked the strength to move. He decided it was best to close his eyes.

When he opened his eyes a second time, the surroundings were too bright for him. Right in front of him, silhouetted against the sun, stood a cat. It was licking the blood off Adam's face. The cat didn't seem bothered by Adam waking up; it looked at him for a moment and then went right back to its business.

Adam could still feel the agony of the previous night. Everywhere Mark had hit him was throbbing. Still, he felt like he could get up. He groaned in pain as his ribs stabbed into his chest. When the cat lost interest and wandered off after failing to reach Adam's face, Adam pushed himself up using the only hand he thought was still intact. A small cry of pain escaped him as his shoulder pulsed with agony. He put his weight on his legs.

When he finally stood up completely, a momentary wave of satisfaction washed over him because Mark hadn't broken his leg bones. At least he could walk. Although a wave of pain rippled through his upper body with every breath, he muttered to himself, "It could have been worse. At least nothing is broken. Well, maybe my nose..."

Adam walked out of the alley with heavy steps. When the people around him noticed him, they winced and moved away, changing their paths. He was staggering forward, covered in blood. As he clenched his left hand into a fist, he gritted his teeth in pain, and his teeth throbbed. He noticed another piece of a tooth moving in his mouth. Or maybe it had just broken off now; he didn't know. The pain was keeping him from thinking straight.

In his worst times—which usually meant all the time for Adam—he would come to Church Street. Passing by a few restaurants, he stopped in front of one of the doors of the four-story terraced houses. He shoved his hand into his pocket and searched for his key for a while, but couldn't find it. Cursing, he pushed the door. It was locked. Sighing, he leaned his back against the wall next to the door. He winced, as if recalling the moment Mark had pinned him against the wall. Though the memory was faint, the pain was still fresh.

He slowly slid his back down the wall and sat on the ground with a groan. As he pulled his knees toward himself, it felt like a knife was stabbing into his stomach, so he let them go immediately. There were already twenty knives stabbing into his chest anyway. He closed his eyes, wondering if the others were still alive. Leaning his head against the side of the building, he closed his eyes.

Adam opened his eyes as the door creaked open. Blinking, he lifted his head. A man wearing a hat and a long coat, sporting a sharp mustache, stepped out. Without looking at Adam, the man said, "I don't have any spare change. Please go beg somewhere else."

"Are you serious?" Adam managed to say when the man was three or four steps away. The man froze like a statue, his eyes widening as he turned around. Seeing Adam stretched out against the side of the building, his mouth opened in shock and horror.

"Who did you let beat you up this time?" the man asked, trying to collect himself as he rushed to help his blood-and-mud-covered friend. When he placed his hand on Adam's right shoulder, Adam groaned in pain.

"The other arm, Ed!" he said, and with the help of Edward Stevenson, he stood up. "Good to see you, by the way... I think I lost my key."

"Oh, damn it! What did you do this time? Your face... It looks like someone played American football on it."

"You're not wrong. It was Mark who did it."

"Gargantuan Mark?"

"Do you know any other?"

"No. For God's sake, Adam! Why don't you get a proper job and work like everyone else? I told you that you wouldn't be able to handle the debt you got into! Didn't I?"

"We'll figure something out. But first, I need some bandages. And a few stitches, I think. How does my nose look?"

"Like it never existed."

"Great," Adam said warily. "Is there any medicine at home? At least a painkiller or something?"

"Whiskey?"

"Good enough," Adam said, and leaning on Edward, he began to climb the apartment stairs. Groaning with every step, he managed to make it to the second floor. Edward opened the door, led Adam to the first room inside, and left him on the sofa. Adam collapsed onto the sofa in pain. He groaned as he writhed around, trying to find the most comfortable position.

Meanwhile, Edward left Adam to fetch the whiskey and the first aid kit. When he returned, he set the first aid kit on the floor, and the whiskey right next to it. Then he stepped out of the living room again, returning shortly after with a cloth and some water.

"My head feels like it's going to split open, Ed. Let's start with the whiskey," Adam said, sitting up. Edward handed Adam his glass. After staring at the glass for a moment, Adam reached out, grabbed the whiskey bottle instead, and chugged from it.

"You need clean clothes too. I can give you one of my sweaters that runs small."

"That would be nice. I guess walking around naked on the street is the only thing I haven't done yet."

"You talk like you're going to do that soon too," Edward said with a small smile. Then, he began to clean Adam's face with the damp cloth. "Brother, let this be the last time, please. You know I'm always by your side, but if this keeps up, soon only your head will make it to my house. I'll back you up until the end." Once the blood on Adam's face was cleaned, Edward began to dress the large gash on Adam's nose. As Adam groaned silently, Edward continued to speak.

"Like I said, we always watch each other's backs, but soon you won't have a back left for me to watch. You're practically begging for everyone to kick your ass." Adam winced in pain as Edward moved on to the stitches after dressing the wound. "Will you stop that? I can't stitch your wound if you keep glaring like that."

Once the stitching was finished, Adam took another sip of the whiskey with a sigh.

"You're right, Ed. And I promise you, this is the last time. I'll find a way to pay my debt to Woods and put an end to all of this. I'll get a job and straighten my life out. I promise. I swear on my honor."

"If you have any left, that is."

Adam sighed.

"Does a brother's oath work?" he asked, squinting one eye and raising his eyebrow at Edward.

"As long as you keep your word, it doesn't really matter what you swear on," Edward said, pulling the bandages out of the kit. Adam took off his shirt. After wrapping his body and his hand with Edward's help, Adam straightened up.

"As always, thank you for watching my back, Ed. I guess I'm indebted to you again."

"Rest assured, Adam, paying my debt to you isn't something that ends with two stitches."

Adam started to laugh, but his laughter was cut short by pain. He winced.

"Let's just say there are no debts between two brothers then."

"Deal," Edward said, and brought over his old clothes from the other room. First, he held them up against himself; they really did look short, just as he said. Then he held them up against Adam. They were a perfect fit. Adam took the sweater and, with Edward's help, dressed slowly. He slid his arms into the coat, absorbing the pain step by step.

"When all of this is over, I'll visit you again. Then we'll find me a job. Who knows, maybe I'll clean the floors at the jeweler's to start with."

"Instead of losing my clothes and my whiskey for free, I'd rather my workplace be clean at least. If you're hungry, let me give you something to eat before you go."

"Thanks, but my teeth aren't in any condition to chew right now," Adam said, grimacing. He ran his tongue over his broken teeth until they throbbed as if struck by a cold chill. "I'd better go. I'll find a way to pay my debt."

"Alright. Take care of yourself. Be careful."

"See you, brother. See you," Adam said, and left the house.

After a long and grueling flight of stairs, Adam's feet hit the pavement once more. His pain had dulled a bit. While the whiskey took away some of the pain, it had taken an equal toll on his balance. But he figured it was better than the knives stabbing into his chest with every step.

After walking for nearly an hour, he reached his own home. His house didn't look nearly as good as Edward's. Nor was it an apartment like his; it was an old, detached house. It was an old, dilapidated place that looked entirely ramshackle. But still, it was Adam's home.

"Home, sweet home," he said with a sigh, reaching for the door handle. He inserted the key, and after a few forced twists, the door opened. He stepped inside and headed straight to the bedroom, throwing himself onto the bed. Ignoring the foul stench emanating from his messy, dirty bed, he closed his eyes. He didn't have the energy to keep them open anyway. He lost himself among his thoughts and fell asleep shortly after.

When Adam opened his eyes, he noticed that he didn't feel pain as he breathed in and out. Filled with hope and joy, he bolted upright in bed. A sharp cramp seized his stomach, sending him falling to his knees on the floor.

"Damn you, Mark," he managed to mutter through his broken teeth. He forced himself to stand up. Taking deep breaths, he took a few steps and walked into his kitchen.

The counter and the stove were covered in stains everywhere. Brown, yellow, green... Various stains were scattered across the white counter and the black stove. A little further ahead stood a small refrigerator. Holding his stomach with one hand, he approached the fridge and pulled the door open. As the door swung open, a dark shadow leaped out at him. He let out a shriek, lost his balance, and fell. Landing hard on his back reminded him of the moment he had been slammed against the wall, bringing the accompanying pain right back with it. Adam groaned in agony once more.

"Damn rats!" he said, straightening up again. Taking deep breaths, he dropped himself onto the chair standing right next to the counter. He just sat there, exhausted. Then he bowed his head and looked at the clothes he had received from Edward. There was a white sweater and a dark brown coat. Both were clothes far too high in quality for Adam. While Edward was doing everything to keep him alive, Adam felt for a moment as if he were trying to get himself killed. Alongside the ache of regret, he shoved his hand into the coat pocket. His fingers brushed against a few pieces of paper.

Sighing, he pulled his hand out. Looking at the paper bills, he sat up straight. He knew he couldn't pay off his debt with this. With a sigh, he decided to use the money to have one last good meal. He went to the bathroom to wash his face. The water stung the moment it touched the stitched parts of his nose. Grimacing, Adam looked into the mirror. He turned his head from side to side to check how the wound looked; it was in terrible shape. Then he ran his hand through his hair, trying to smooth it out as best as he could, and left his house.

He stopped in front of a restaurant about half an hour away. Tilting his head up, he looked at the sign. The words "Birmin Breakfast" had been sitting there the exact same way for years. The lettering was dark red, and the sign itself was black. Two flowers standing next to it were the restaurant's symbol. Adam figured both flowers were violets.

After standing in front of the door for a moment, Adam put a smile on his face and went inside. The interior wasn't as crowded as he expected. On the left side stood a long counter, with red stools lined up in front of it. On the right side, there were large booths facing each other. In the center stood a few round tables surrounded by chairs. Adam slipped into the

booth in the furthest corner, as he always did. Hoping his forced smile looked alright, he sat down and waited.

Before long, a woman around Adam's age approached his table with a small notepad in hand. With his messy hair and long beard, Adam looked much older than her.

"Hello, Adam. How are you?" the woman asked cheerfully. Adam lifted his head to look at her. Her blonde bob cut looked as beautiful as ever. When her brown eyes met Adam's black ones, he forgot all the pain he had been enduring for a moment. As his heart fluttered, the woman's smile suddenly vanished. Her eyes widened. It was Diana Williams.

"Oh my God! What happened to you?" she cried out loudly. Realizing her mistake, she immediately sat down across from Adam. "For God's sake, Adam! What happened to you?"

"Just a minor scratch. It's nothing important, Diana," Adam said, trying to look at Diana Williams with a wide smile. He instantly regretted smiling and decided to hide his broken teeth.

Diana sighed, putting her head in her hands.

"Did Woods do this to you?"

"No... I mean, well..."

"It was Mark then," Diana said, raising her eyebrows. Adam nodded in confirmation. "How much time do you have left? To pay the debt, I mean?"

"It was two days when they put me in this state, but I think it's down to one day now."

"Oh, good Lord! I told you! This was a mistake from the very beginning. Borrowing money from Woods was a complete mistake!"

"You know I had no other choice. It was the only way I could pay Edward's bail."

Diana sighed.

"You're right. So, what do you plan to do now?"

"Honestly, I have no idea. Is there anything warm to eat? A soup would be better."

"Of course. Wait here," Diana said, rising from the table. Adam looked at his own reflection in the window right next to him. Despite his messy hair and his long, untamed beard, he smiled, thinking he looked okay. When his lips parted wider, he saw his shattered teeth, and all his happiness vanished in an instant.

"Chicken soup," Diana said, placing the bowl on the table and reclaiming her seat. "Enjoy."

"Thank you, Diana," Adam said, smiling without showing his teeth. Then, he began to sip his soup.

As Adam ate his soup hungrily, Diana watched him with a frown.

"When was the last time you ate?"

Adam paused his eating for a moment and looked at Diana. Then he averted his gaze. Looking into her eyes made it too difficult for Adam to think about anything else.

"I think the last thing I had was breakfast." He stared at the napkin holder for a moment.
"Yesterday morning."

"Damn it, Adam! Why do you treat yourself like this? It hurts me to see you this way." Diana sighed. "I want you to be okay."

Adam's breath caught in his throat. This time, it wasn't from a kick to the stomach. Excitement, rather than pain, was fluttering in his gut.

"Thank you, Diana. Truly. Just you sitting here makes me feel better. I think my wounds heal faster when I'm around you."

Diana looked at Adam with a small smile. Then, her smile faded.

"The money situation still gives me chills. It scares me. Did you tell Edward?"

"No, of course not! I told him I lost the money gambling. So he doesn't know. And he won't know either. I'd go to prison for my brother if I had to. You know that."

"So what are you going to do?"

"I'll find a way." Adam sighed as he looked deep into Diana's eyes. "I'll be honest. One of the reasons I came... was to say goodbye. If I can't find the money by tomorrow... I don't know what will happen to me. But one thing I do know is... I care about you."

As a tear trickled down from Adam's eyes, he sniffed. Diana sat frozen, as if a lump had formed in her throat. She opened her mouth but couldn't say anything for a moment.

"No..." she finally managed to say. "Don't... don't think like that." She took one of the napkins from the table to wipe her welling eyes. "Get that out of your head. If you have to... if you have to, you run away from here. But no... I don't want you to think about such a thing." She took another napkin and blew her nose. "In fact... next Monday. If you don't have to run away, come to Kings Heath Park. At... let's meet there at seven o'clock. But if you do have to run, come to say one last goodbye to me. And then get as far away from here as possible. Because Woods..."

Adam looked into Diana's eyes, holding back his tears. With a bittersweet smile, he silently admired her beauty for a moment.

"I'd call that a date, just so you know." Seeing a bittersweet smile form on Diana's face as well, he felt a lump form in his throat. But he kept speaking. "I'm sorry. I'm sorry for being so late to tell you. For not telling you... how I feel about you."

"You'll tell me all of it at Kings Heath Park," Diana said, trying to maintain her bittersweet smile. "I know it. You'll come, and we'll talk about everything."

Adam sighed and wiped away Diana's falling tear.

"I'm sorry. For everything. But I will fix it all. No matter what, I'll fix it. Take care of yourself, Diana," Adam said, rising from his seat. Diana wiped her remaining tears and stood up too. She paused for a second. Then, taking a swift step forward, she wrapped her arms tightly around Adam. Adam returned her hug.

"You be careful too," Diana managed to say. "I'm sorry too. I could have made a move myself, but... but I didn't."

"You're not to blame for anything, don't apologize. And... don't worry. I'll be at the park on Monday at seven."

Diana let go of Adam with a shaky sigh.

"Monday then. Take care of yourself until then."

"Monday," Adam said. "You take care too." Then, with quick paces, he walked out of Birmin Breakfast. He couldn't hold back his tears any longer. He began to cry as he made his way toward his house. He sobbed openly, completely unbothered by the people around him, until no more tears could come out of his eyes. His feelings hurt far more than the bruises on his stomach and back, or the gash on his face. His chest felt tight. As the ache spread throughout his entire body, the only thing he could do was walk home.

When he entered the house, he stood still for a moment. Closing the door behind him, he collapsed to the floor with a groan. He didn't know what to do. Holding his head in his hands, he began to think. He stayed where he was for a while, breathing slowly. He racked his brain trying to figure out how he could pay off Woods' debt.

Only one way came to his mind. Taking deep breaths for a while, he stared into space, lost in thought. When he decided no other idea would come to him, he stood up. He glanced around as if someone were watching him. There was no one there. Still, he kept looking around until he reached his bedroom.

Arriving in his room, he stepped in front of the nightstand right next to his bed. There was a photo on it. A picture of a soldier. Adam's eyes filled with tears once more. He dropped to his knees in front of the photograph.

"I'm sorry, Dad. I let you down, but... but I have to do this," he said quietly, a lump forming in his throat with every word.

He slowly pulled out the drawer sitting right beneath the photo. Inside lay a folded British flag. He lifted the flag gently and placed it on what he thought was the cleanest part of the bed. Carefully, as if it contained a bomb, he unfolded the flag. When he opened the folded flag completely, he saw the black pistol inside. Rested on top of it were military dog tags. Adam sighed. With choking sobs, he took the gun into his hand.

"I'm sorry, but I have to do this," he whispered again. This time, his voice came out steadier. Standing up, he made sure the safety was on and tucked it into the waistband of his pants. Then, he opened the wardrobe facing his bed. The inside was far messier than the rest of the room. T-shirts and sweaters were tangled together in several heaps. The pants were too. All the shirts on hangers had fallen down, covering the piles of t-shirts.

At first, Adam just shoved the clothes from one side to the other, trying to find what he was looking for. Realizing he couldn't find it that way, he began throwing his clothes out of the wardrobe onto his bed one by one. Finally, he found the ski mask he was searching for. He lifted the mask and held it up in front of him.

Looking at the mask, he felt a tightness in his chest. Old days, his past crimes came to mind. Every crime he had ever committed flashed before him like a movie reel. Closing his eyes tightly, he finally lowered the mask. As his chest tightened, breathing became harder and harder. On top of that, remembering Mark's kick stole his breath away entirely for a moment.

It didn't take long for Adam to calm himself down. He was used to it by now. No matter what happened, he had learned how to soothe himself. He would close his eyes, regulate his breathing, and empty his mind. His escape depended on what he was trying to run from.

He slid backward from where he was sitting. Groaning, he backed up until his back hit the wall. His stomach still throbbed whenever he moved. He let out a deep breath as he leaned against the wall, comforting himself. And he just sat there.

He sat until the sunlight filtering into the room gradually faded, painting the space in shades of orange. As evening began to fall, Adam used the bed for support to stand up. Taking deep breaths, he looked at the ski mask in his hand once more. He stuffed the mask into his coat pocket.

After waiting for the sun to set completely, he stepped out of the house. He tried to take the darkest paths possible, staying as far away from the streetlights as he could. He entered dark alleyways where there was no light at all. Even though he couldn't see his surroundings, he kept walking toward the pinprick of light shining at the end of the street.

Eventually, he managed to reach one of Birmingham's wealthy streets. Of course, he didn't walk straight onto the street. He just waited in the nearest unlit side alley. As the darkness of the night hid him, he pulled on his mask. He leaned his back against the wall. For a split second, he flinched at the memory of Mark, but considering where he was, he wiped the memory away instantly. He focused on the present—on what he was about to attempt.

He waited for a very long time, watching one of the city's busy streets. It was crowded, but unlike other streets, it wasn't filled with drunks and the homeless. The crowd on this street consisted of women with arms full of shopping bags, or wealthy businessmen wandering through rows of jewelers and boutiques to buy trinkets and jewelry for their wives. Others had simply stepped out for a stroll in the cool night air after enjoying a fine meal at an expensive restaurant.

Adam scrutinized the people one by one and waited patiently. He knew that if he mingled with them, he would get caught. And if he got caught, he would go to prison. He was certain that one of Woods' men would visit him in prison. So he waited. He waited in the darkness, unconcerned with what time it was or how much time had passed. He knew that eventually, someone would come down the dark street where he sat huddled. He waited by the edge of the wall, his gun ready.

After a long or short while—Adam hadn't really paid attention—an elegant woman took her first step into the darkness. She wore a fur coat draped over her shoulders, and underneath, a glamorous, long turquoise dress. She was tall, and with her heels, she looked even taller—nearly the same height as Adam. Her brown bob cut verged on black as she stepped deeper into the gloom. With every step she took, a sharp *clack-clack* echoed from her heels, sounding like someone knocking on a door. Around her neck was a necklace that had caught the light just before she entered the dark alley; a gold chain bearing a large blue diamond pendant. It

was a necklace far too large and flashy to match the woman's delicate frame. Taking a deep breath, Adam closed the distance between them in three steps and pressed the gun against the woman's back.

"Make a sound and I pull the trigger."

The woman wanted to scream in terror, but her voice was cut off before it could even start.

"P-please... I have two children waiting for me at home. Please let me go."

"Don't worry, lady," Adam said in the coldest voice he could muster. "I only need your necklace. You can go."

"But... this necklace is the last keepsake left to me by my father," the woman said, her voice cracking more and more as fear and desperation bled into her tone. Adam could have sworn she was lying.

"I'll take good care of your father's keepsake, don't worry," Adam said, grabbing the woman by the shoulder and turning her around. He reached his hand out toward where he remembered the necklace sitting, near the neckline of her dress. The necklace was right where he recalled. He was just about to grab the diamond and pull when he heard a voice from behind.

"Leave the lady alone!" the voice shouted, and out of the darkness, a figure lunged at Adam. Cursing, Adam crashed to the ground, slamming his back painfully against the pavement. As his entire body tensed up—recalling the time Mark had thrown him down—a loud sound rang out. *Bang!* Terrified, Adam froze where he lay for a moment. He could feel warm blood pooling, flowing from the level of his stomach. But there was no pain. Because it wasn't his own blood.

Along with the gunshot, the sound of the high heels echoed like a galloping horse as the woman fled. But Adam felt too terrible to worry about her.

"Oh my God!" he gasped in horror, pushing the man off him to the side. He couldn't think straight. "Oh my God!" he shrieked again. As his breathing quickened, his hands moved over the man lying on the ground, searching for the wound. Finding it quickly, he began to press down on it.

"Damn it! I... I'm so sorry! I thought the safety was on! I didn't mean to kill anyone! God... what have I done?"

As tears streamed from Adam's eyes, he froze at the touch of a hand on his face—the hand reaching up from the ground. The man was still alive.

"We are all... we are all sinners. What matters is... what we do... to be forgiven. What... what prices we pay."

"You're alive! Please hold on! Help! Is anyone there? Someone help! God, I'm so sorry..."

"If... if you're truly sorry... seek forgiveness. Before you are brought before God... seek forgiveness. Whatever it takes... you must pay... the penance..." the man said, and with that final word, his last breath slipped from his lips.

"No, no, no..."

Adam wept uncontrollably as he pressed down on the man's wound. Then he bowed his head over the man's chest.

"No. You can't die! No, no..."

When he couldn't hear a heartbeat, he placed his hands on the man's chest. He pumped his heart with all his might, again and again. But it was no use.

"Damn it! Come on, open your eyes!" Just as Adam spoke, the blare of a siren echoed, followed by the reflection of blue lights flashing at the entrance of the alley. The police had arrived at the scene. Adam looked at the man one last time. Weeping, he slowly stood up.

"I'm... I'm sorry... My intention... I didn't mean to hurt anyone," he said quietly, offering his explanation to the lifeless body. But he received no answer. He began to step backward slowly.

"I'm sorry," he finally said, turned around, and bolted. He ran as fast as he possibly could.

He couldn't think of anything. Anguish had taken over his heart and mind. His head throbbed, as if the memory of the killing was expanding in his brain, trying to burst out. Or perhaps his mind wanted to escape this pain, but this moment—which he would never forget—was already etched into the depths of his consciousness.

He only realized he had been running for a long time when his breath failed him. Until then, he had kept sprinting blindly in a fixed direction. But finally, he stopped. Leaning his hands on his knees, he gasped for air. With his lips and throat parched, he looked around. People were going about their ways, entirely oblivious to his state, as they always did.

Adam looked down at himself. Right in the center of his sweater, there was a dark stain. It wasn't obvious that it was a bloodstain; the dark color of the sweater masked the color of the blood. But the damp darkness of it was clear. And of course, a pungent smell of iron rushed into Adam's nose.

As he caught his breath, he looked around. Trying to figure out where he was, he realized he was still wearing the mask. Without a moment's delay, he ripped the mask off and shoved it into his pocket. He set off toward Edward's house.

The moment Edward opened his door, Adam threw himself inside. He hugged his old friend tightly, weeping onto Edward's shoulder as if pouring out all his grief. Surprised, Edward didn't know what to do at first, but then he closed the door and decided to return his friend's embrace.

"Man, what's wrong? What happened?" he asked anxiously. Then, the smell of iron hit his nose. Holding Adam by his shoulders and pulling him back a step, he saw the massive stain covering his stomach.

"Please tell me that isn't your blood!" Edward said in terror.

"No," Adam said quietly, shaking his head. "I wish... I wish it were mine, but..."

Edward pulled his old friend close and hugged him tightly. Silently and patiently, he waited for his friend to explain.

Adam stepped back a pace. He looked at Edward with bloodshot eyes, a lump forming in his throat. He pondered for a moment how to say it—what to say.

"Ed... I killed someone," he finally managed. And the moment he said it, his knees buckled. "It was just an innocent person passing by the street... He wanted to stop it... I... one last time... you know I needed the money and..."

Edward sat cross-legged on the floor next to Adam, placing a hand on his friend's shoulder.

"Adam, we're in this together, just like the old days. Will you wipe your tears? I need you to collect your thoughts. To forget the past and focus on the future. What I mean is, we need a plan. What are we going to do?"

Adam looked at Edward, taking deep, heavy breaths.

"But... this time it's different. I killed an innocent person. Before this... we never did anything more than theft! But taking a life..."